Privacy

"I don't want to appear there anymore," the girl told her. This is recounted by her mother, Argentine actress Griselda Siciliani, on television. They went to a clothing store, and the saleswoman greeted the mother: "Hello, Margarita! How are you? Have a nice day." When the 6-year-old girl asked her mother why an unknown saleswoman knew her name, her mother replied that it was probably because of the stories she uploaded to Instagram. Very clearly, the girl told her: "I don't want to appear there anymore."

A few years ago, for several days, we all talked about the same thing: the Nordelta "siesta lady." A woman who, in a WhatsApp audio message, made at least controversial comments, complaining about the lack of "moral and visual aesthetic codes" among neighbors who drank mate by the shared pool. The media called it "the viral audio of the year." No one called it a private conversation between a person and their real estate agent.

This type of situation, where private conversations or WhatsApp audios are leaked to the media and become news or go viral, has become completely commonplace and increasingly frequent, with no debate whatsoever about why we publicly discuss private conversations. It's not just about viralization or celebrities; this also applies in other areas.

A few years ago, I went on a training trip. There were 30 or 40 of us who, for a week, shared various training workshops. I remember at one point a girl asked me to take a picture of her with other participants and handed me her phone. I saw it was locked, so I said, "Can you unlock it, please, so I can take the picture?" And she, already three meters away, positioned for the photo, somewhat shouted to me: "I'll give you the password! I don't mind you having it." Something I got a little closer to. I told my wife, "This one, having your password..."

And other stories, other situations. On any given Sunday, at family lunch, many laugh about Dad's WhatsApp group with his friends who share pornography all day long as if they were teenagers. Very funny, except that most of those videos are shared without the consent of their protagonists.

At that same lunch, another family couple took a photo of their newborn baby girl and uploaded it to the internet, uploaded it to social media. The baby is three months old, already has her Instagram profile, has dozens of photos published online and dozens or more followers. A study by the British organization for the show [likely "for children" or similar, given the context] states that children, by the time they reach five years old, have around a thousand photos published online. A thousand photos in five years: 200 photos per year, 16 per month, 4 per week, one photo every 2 days. The modern online family. When I chose this data, it occurred to me, let's see if I had a thousand photos published online, and I don't. At 35 years old, I have fewer photos published online than most 5-year-old boys and girls in the world, despite never having made a decision about their participation in social media.

It's not just about individuals, or families. This also affects the State; it also affects businesses. This morning, at a beautiful Saturday hour, half past eight in the morning, I received a phone call. Anyone starting the weekend without breakfast, I'm sure we're all wishing for the same thing, which is to switch cell phone companies. My phone rings and a friend from Córdoba, very kindly, offers me a promotion to switch providers. I told him it sounded interesting, that I

was willing to proceed, if he could first tell me where they got my phone number and who gave them consent to call me at whatever time they pleased.

This also applies to the State. Not to mention public organizations that hold citizens' data, personal data that is often used by officials for personal or political purposes. "We have the data, the name, the ID, the phone number of a person; well, let's [possibly "derive" or "use"] that database and use it to conduct a political campaign or telephone survey. And if they don't answer, since we have the data, why don't we affiliate them with the party?" "The data is there, why not use it?" Companies use it, share it, and sometimes even sell it, because for them it's just data—it's neither personal nor private. Just data.

I could go on all day talking about this, and as you can see, these stories have a common pattern: privacy. That's what I wanted to talk about today: the imperative need for us as a society to discuss how much we value having a private life, because, *a priori*, it seems not that much.

Privacy is the right we have as individuals for our lives to be protected by confidentiality; that is, that we can decide who, at what moment, and what aspects of our lives, our actions, our decisions, our opinions are known. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights states that it is a human right. Its Article number 12 says that private life is a human right, and it's interesting that it's not such an ancient human right; in fact, it's more of a modern human right. Until a couple of centuries ago, it wasn't uncommon for people to change clothes, bathe, or even have sex in front of others. Today, however, it's unthinkable to take a shower in front of other people without it [being a decision]. It is clearly a private act.

Despite computers and the internet being over 30 years old, I believe that in the last half, in the last 10 or 15 years, this has become more evident with the emergence of platforms or technologies that truly challenge privacy: smartphones, cameras, connectivity, social media, big data. These are different terms that, in one way or another, modify how we behave with data, with personal data, with private data, and invite us to rethink this concept of privacy.

The reality is that in these 15 years, despite these changes, debates around privacy haven't been that many. Perhaps there was a small turning point last year when the scandal between Facebook and Cambridge Analytica occurred. A scandal that ended with Mark Zuckerberg, the owner and founder of the world's largest social network, seated, with a live broadcast via the internet and all the media there in front of the U.S. Congress, explaining how his company used users' personal data.

Social media has become a fundamental part of the modern privacy framework. These are the terms of use for the social networks we use most. On your right you have Snapchat, on your left you have Instagram. Our privacy cannot depend on us reading these texts. And at the same time, how much can we demand from social media companies? After all, they are businesses. There must probably be some balance between their responsibility and their need to do business, a balance that we are probably still seeking.

But in the meantime, it's important that we think about how we act and how we understand and perceive social media. Let's see how we used to think about them: what's here is a traditional commercial transaction. Well, I think we all see that there is a client, a user, there is a provider, there is a product or it could be a service, and of course, you have to pay for that product or service.

As we used to see social media, or at least mostly: there is a provider and a user. That provider, Facebook to cite an example, could be any company or any of these social networks. Well, these companies give us a product: the applications, the social media service. Well, and fortunately, they are free. You enter, register, and use them. It's great, we have great services, and they are also free.

Now, are they free? If we said they are companies and they make money, I don't see the money. Are they non-profit organizations? There is a somewhat evolved vision of this idea that unfortunately, even though for many of you at this moment it sounds obvious that they are not, it is unfortunately the most common idea: "let's use social media because it's free." But there is a somewhat evolved idea that is that we use social media but they are not free, that we pay for them with our data. Many of you may have heard: "social media is not free, you pay for it with your data."

I insist that even though it is an evolved idea, it is still somewhat incomplete. At the end of the month, do companies pay their users a salary with data? Do shareholders seek to earn data? Obviously not. They are companies that earn a lot of money and are worth a lot of money. So, let's try to see it in reverse: there is a social media provider (I insist, Facebook is an example) and there is someone who pays money, who gives them the money. And the one who pays the money is always the client. If the one who pays the money is the client, obviously the clients of Facebook and other ad-based services are the advertisers, they are the companies that pay to have ads on these services. And that's perfectly fine, because it's their business model.

Now, if we are not the client, what place do we have in this picture? We are the carrot. We are the product. Social media is not free, nor do we pay for it with our data. We are the product, and in the best of cases, our data is the raw material. But that's how social media makes money, and that's how we have to understand them. In the midst of this circus, we dance and expose our private lives on these services, and we begin to lose the line between what is private and what is public, and we live with the illusion that this private life we expose online will never be used against us.

What companies do with their practices, which is, of course, important; what the State does with its laws and controls; but fundamentally, what we do with our habits will determine where privacy goes in the future and what place it will occupy in the society we want to live in.

Let me tell you one more story. Many times at work, in meetings with friends, the debate arises about whether our partners have our cell phone password or not. A relatively modern debate. The moment someone says no, at least in a group of men in the modern era, there is a response, unfortunately this response comes out: "that's a pirate," "you don't share your cell phone." It could even be the debate between a couple discussing whether they will really share access to a personal device or not. Let's think for a second what is hidden behind this idea: "Only if you are a bad person do you have the right to privacy." This is one of the biggest myths about privacy: that only someone who has something to hide has the right to privacy.

And this idea is terrible: not to think of privacy as the human right to have intimacy, to choose what we want to be known and what not, and that not necessarily all of that is something bad. There is a dichotomy with this problem that is very well represented in a phrase from George Orwell's book "1984" which says: "Until they become conscious they will not rebel. But if they do not rebel, they will never become conscious." Something very similar happens with privacy. The ones responsible for us becoming aware of the importance of privacy are companies, the

State, the media, which are the same ones who benefit if we don't protect our personal data and don't care about our intimate lives.

To conclude, I invite you on a journey. Each of you, think of a destination you'd like to visit, a beautiful place you know or don't know, very far away. It has to be far, we have to go by plane. Imagine how much you want to visit that place. Imagine preparing for the trip, arriving at the airport, boarding the plane, ready for takeoff. The emotion that traveling to that place implies for us, the joy of getting to know that place again for the first time. The plane takes off, we are already on our way, with all that a vacation and a new trip implies: joy, excitement.

And when we are in the air, already flying, our companion to the right, our companion to the left, look at us, smile at us, put their hand in their pocket and pull out a pack of cigarettes. Each one lights a cigarette, and then each of the 300 passengers on the plane starts lighting not just one, but all the cigarettes they want in the next ten hours of this beautiful trip we are taking. But that trip no longer seems so beautiful with the smoke inside the plane, does it?

This very thing happened to me a few months ago: I was watching a series set in the 60s where the protagonists smoked on the plane, as well as in work meetings or in enclosed spaces. I am almost certain that any of you would react if someone here now lit a cigarette inside the auditorium. However, it wasn't that long ago that this changed. 20 years ago, when Google was created, you could still smoke on some commercial airplanes. 15 years ago, when Facebook was created, in Argentina you could still smoke in enclosed spaces and restaurants. However, today it seems crazy to us. When things change, they seem obvious, but that change is sometimes very slow.

I hope that this is the slow path we take with privacy, but that we must give the necessary time and debates so that, as I always say, the pendulum finds a comfortable position between the place privacy held in the modern era over the last two centuries, and the almost negligible value we seem to give to privacy in the last ten or fifteen years. And hopefully, and it largely depends on us, that it settles in some intermediate place where we probably redefine it, but yes, I insist, above all, we protect it. And that privacy becomes the cigarette of the future, and who knows if one day, many years from now, some child or grandchild of my generation might say: "To think that my dad had an Instagram profile created for him when he was a baby and everyone looked at his photos, how crazy!

Exercise: Privacy in the Digital Age

Read the following statements carefully and mark them as **True (T)** or **False (F)** based solely on the text.

1. Griselda Siciliani's daughter no longer wanted to appear on Instagram after a saleswoman recognized her from her mother's stories. (T / F)
2. The text suggests that the virality of private conversations or WhatsApp audios is a recent and uncommon phenomenon. (T / F)
3. According to the author, the common pattern in all the stories mentioned (from the Instagram girl to the use of data by the State) is a lack of transparency. (T / F)

4. Article 12 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights states that private life is a modern human right, not as ancient as other rights. (T / F)
5. The scandal between Facebook and Cambridge Analytica is presented as an important turning point in the debate about privacy. (T / F)
6. The author claims that social media platforms are free because companies do not seek to make a profit from their users. (T / F)
7. In the social media business model, the text concludes that users are the "product" and their data is the "raw material." (T / F)
8. One of the biggest myths about privacy, according to the text, is that only those who have something to hide need privacy. (T / F)
9. The author uses the analogy of smoking on airplanes and in enclosed spaces to illustrate that the concept and acceptance of privacy have been and will be immutable over time. (T / F)